salutation. In these paintings we see women stringing up bunting made of auspicious mango leaves to celebrate the birth of a child, and the energetic beating of huge drums and the blowing of trumpets to announce the victorious arrival of the Padshah. There are also troubling details such as the degraded and piteous condition of prisoners of war wearing animal skins over their faces, which Abu'l Fazl glosses over. Startlingly timeless details are shown, too, like women labourers wearing glass-studded brocade cloth in a construction scene, just like women continue to do in India today.

The paintings show a court that was always changing, incorporating different elements from its new courtiers. So from a purely Persian aesthetic painted by Farrukh Beg in the scene showing a Mughal emissary and the rebel Bahadur Khan, the court paintings become more exuberant and dynamic and incorporate Rajput clothes, Rajput courtiers, indigenous musicians and instruments, and details of courtly life that show a much more expansive interpretation of the Mughal Empire than that shown in the accompanying text. In one such example, art historian Geeti Sen has suggested that in the painting showing the court dancers of Mandu being presented to Akbar after the defeat of Baz Bahadur, we can see a possible route for the introduction of the Kathak style of dance into the Mughal court through these famous dancers from Malwa.

And, finally, there is the alluring possibility that some of the paintings of well-known amirs and courtiers, and indeed of Akbar himself, are actual likenesses in the manner of portraits. The art of portraiture in Mughal painting has usually been attributed to Padshah Jahangir, with his fascination for psychologically acute images. But Akbar, too, was intensely and passionately interested in the deep desires that motivated people and a corresponding need, his whole life, to viscerally understand and 'read' the faces and characters of people. Abu'l Fazl wrote that Akbar had commissioned an enormous portrait album in which 'those that have passed away have received a new life, and those who are still alive have immortality promised them'. Geeti Sen has proposed that a number of the paintings of key figures from Akbar's life including Bahadur Khan, Munim Khan, Mirza Sulaiman, and Azim Khan, among others, appear to be actual likenesses. There are even a handful of enigmatic images showing moments of high emotion—blistering rage, haunting introspection or grateful celebration in Akbar's life—which seem to show finely-drawn likenesses of the Padshah himself, reflecting these different moods. These images are